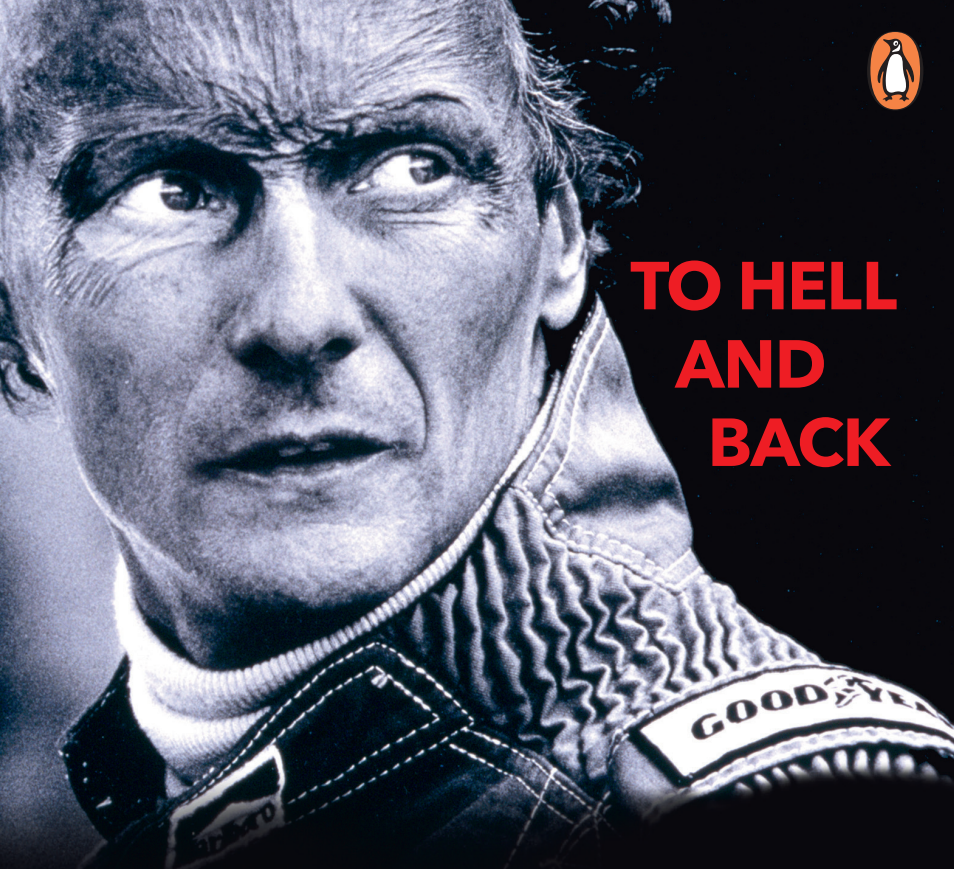


A black and white close-up portrait of Niki Lauda, looking upwards and to the left with a serious expression. He is wearing a racing suit with a Goodyear logo on the sleeve.

**TO HELL
AND
BACK**

'A remarkable individual in every way' **DAMON HILL**

NIKI LAUDA

AN AUTOBIOGRAPHY

TO HELL AND BACK

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AN AUTOBIOGRAPHY

TO HELL AND BACK

Written in collaboration with Herbert Völker

Translated from the German by E.J. Crockett

Introduction and Postscript by Kevin Eason



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THE LEGEND

Kevin Eason

HIGH ABOVE THE phalanx of fans clad in their red caps and shirts was a banner with a haunting picture in stark monochrome of a pair of eyes, scarred by heat and flame, staring down at the bare racetrack below. After the picture was a simple yet heartfelt message: ‘Ciao, Niki.’

The occasion was the 2019 Italian Grand Prix, a race steeped in memories and the history of a team that dates back to the very start of the modern era of Formula 1. Ferrari arrived at the fabled Monza circuit celebrating ninety years since Enzo Ferrari founded his eponymous team, the most famous and successful in the world.

This theatre of speed, carved between the trees of the royal park and the sporting home to Ferrari, has provided the stage for some of the team’s greatest acts, from Alberto Ascari’s first victory at Monza for Ferrari in 1951, the second world championship year, to Michael Schumacher’s tearful (first) retirement in 2006, just minutes after winning his final race for a *Scuderia* that he had helped transform into a powerful and dominant force.

This time, victory belonged to the freshest of Ferrari faces, Charles Leclerc, a stripling of just twenty-one years, who provided the champagne toast for the ninetieth birthday

celebrations. The man whose eyes adorned that poster – and was missing from the Italian Grand Prix for the first time in more than forty years – would have grinned and revelled in one of the greatest sights in all of sport as Leclerc clambered onto the elevated podium to see the faithful Ferrari fans, the *tifosi*, turn the main straight into a river of red with their flags to cheer their new hero.

The memories of many of those teeming fans would have turned to the past, though, and appreciation of the man who looked down on their revelry: Niki Lauda, who died on 20 May 2019, as preparations for the September celebrations reached their climax.

Niki Lauda would have been central to the anniversary party as a key character in the Ferrari story. But he was more than a racing driver, more than a Ferrari driver and more than a man who presided over a team dominating Formula 1 in his final years. He was a symbol of extraordinary courage and determination, whose story was so shocking that even the sci-
ons of Hollywood were taken aback when it was committed to celluloid.

The word ‘legend’ is bandied about too easily in sport: a footballer scores a goal and is instantly crowned a ‘legend’, or a boxer knocks out an opponent and becomes a ‘legend’ because of just one fight. The quote attributed to Ernest Hemingway perhaps comes closest to an explanation of Lauda’s elevation beyond these lesser legends, beyond even the greatest. ‘There are only three sports – bullfighting, mountaineering and motor racing. The rest are merely games,’ Hemingway said. The intent of his analysis was to show that kicking or

hitting a ball or running 100 metres might well be a worthy test of strength or skill, but it is not a contest of mortality.

Niki Lauda drove a car for sport, but crossed the line between life and death and fought back to even greater glory. Lauda really was a legend.

Even people who know nothing of Formula 1 have heard of his crash at the Nürburgring in 1976 when he was dragged from the inferno of his Ferrari so badly injured that he was given the last rites. It was here at Monza before the astonished *tifosi* that he came back from the dead, racing barely forty-two days after a priest attempted to usher him into the afterlife. His wounds bled, he had no eyelids and couldn't blink, so he could hardly see the track ... and he was terrified. Enzo Ferrari was horrified by the publicity that surrounded a comeback that seemed beyond human endurance, but the fans descended on Monza in hordes, encouraged by an hysterical Italian press heaping superlatives on this astonishing hero.

There was no heroic return in Lauda's mind, though. For him, there was simply no alternative. He disguised his fear behind the fireproof balaclava through which blood seeped, and clamped his red helmet firmly onto his raw skull. Now no one could see the fear, trace the trembling and realise that Lauda was not just pitting his skill against the best, but probing the recesses of his mind where the darkest dread waited. A year later, he reclaimed his world championship for Ferrari.

Lauda's first stab at an autobiography came in 1978 with *For the Record – My Years with Ferrari*, translated from the German into English by Diana Mosley, the mother of Max, who provided Lauda's first Formula 1 cars from his March

factory and later became the controversial president of the Fédération Internationale de l'Automobile (FIA), which governed Formula 1.

His second and last autobiography, *To Hell and Back*, was published in 1986 after his final retirement, and it was typically Niki – to the point with no frills and fancies, no doubt dictated at breakneck speed. It covers the years from his childhood to his accident and the battle for the 1976 title with the charismatic James Hunt, and then his departure from Formula 1 and motor racing as a three-times world champion and one of the most successful drivers in the sport, starting at the bottom with BRM and March, then Ferrari, before moving to the Brabham team run by Bernie Ecclestone, and finally McLaren. But Lauda never updated the book, nor told the story of life after Formula 1 as an airline magnate and then his extraordinary return to the track as chairman of the all-conquering Mercedes team that brought an astonishing five world championships for Lewis Hamilton, plus one more for Nico Rosberg, in successive years.

That was to be my job, and I have attempted to focus on the stories, events and anecdotes that would have been in his mind, which means that this book is part-autobiography, part-portrait of the man behind the mask of scars that became a trademark thanks to the Nürburgring.

I had the privilege as motor-racing correspondent for *The Times* to meet Lauda on many occasions at racetracks around the world, and there was one thing a journalist could rely on – that Niki would have an opinion on almost anything to do with motor racing. His opinions carried unique weight,

though, because he had been there, done that and got the scars to prove it. Lauda's image was of a bombastic, curt, driven, even impolite man, and he was all and none of those things, but the measure is that he was adored around the world, could charm even the grumpiest of associates and became one of the most revered of countrymen in his homeland of Austria. John Hogan was the mastermind behind the Philip Morris Marlboro sponsorship that invested hundreds of millions of pounds in Formula 1, including backing Lauda. According to him, Lauda was incredibly well-mannered, 'particularly to women', Hogan said. 'He was always interested in people and put them at their ease. Women of all ages adored him. I think it was his upbringing because, despite his image, he was always courteous and polite.'

Lauda loved pranks and jokes, and would be a fascinating dinner companion with anecdotes that ranged through a life that refused to bow to rules and regulations or respect for authority. Lauda simply did not do rules – unless he could break them. He was his own man, struggling from the suffocating correctness of his privileged childhood to defy his family, who thought motor racing beneath their status in society; standing up to the fearsome Enzo Ferrari, who dominated Formula 1; and then taking on an airline cartel. It was as if he needed life to be a battle against authority and convention.

Hogan, who knew every driver and senior figure in Formula 1 from the early 1970s, including sponsoring and becoming close friends with James Hunt, put it simply: 'You would have to call Niki a maverick. That's the best description.'

Lauda loved a deal and could wring cash from even the tightest of fists to finance his motor-racing career and airline businesses. He started life in Formula 1 with massive debts as he inveigled cash from sponsors persuaded by his assurances of instant success, and ended his life with a fortune estimated by some of almost 500 million euros. He was never driven by money, though, only the deal, the battle and the victory.

‘Niki was always restless, always looking for the next thing,’ according to Bernie Ecclestone, who lured Lauda from Ferrari to his Brabham team. They had sat in a car among the trees of Monza’s royal park after the 1977 Italian Grand Prix, away from prying eyes, to stitch together a deal worth \$1 million a year – a huge price in that era. Lauda secured his second world championship with the *Scuderia* in the United States and then walked away with two Grands Prix of the season remaining to join Ecclestone. Typically, he saw no point in prolonging his association with Ferrari, no matter the success he had enjoyed with them.

And he knew his worth. Before his second season with Brabham, Lauda demanded a pay rise to \$2 million from Ecclestone, who blanched and refused point blank – until they had to attend a meeting with Parmalat, the team’s main sponsor. Ecclestone made the introductions and told executives that the team was prepared for the new 1979 season and that Lauda would be his Number One driver again. ‘No, I won’t,’ Lauda said, stunning the room into silence. Ecclestone and Lauda retreated to a backroom to argue over the \$2 million, but Ecclestone was over a barrel: no pay rise, no lead driver. He paid up.

‘Niki didn’t stand on ceremony. He just got to the point,’ Ecclestone told me. ‘He couldn’t understand why people made a fuss. If something went wrong, he just got on with it and did something else. He didn’t have time for emotion and looking back. He learned a lesson and moved on. People understood that when Niki said good morning, it was before twelve o’clock. They felt comfortable that they could talk and what they got back was just how it is. That’s where he captured a lot of people to support him, because he was straightforward. He didn’t mind criticism.’

Ecclestone had already got his payback after the Nürburg-ring and from a man who could easily have claimed to have kick-started Formula 1 as a global television event. Grand Prix racing on television was a hit-and-miss affair with broadcasts in Europe controlled by the European Broadcasting Union. But Lauda’s crash and spectacular comeback had turned Formula 1 into must-see television and broadcasters were lining up for deals. Ecclestone, who also negotiated for the F1 teams, took on the European Broadcasting Union and started signing contracts with individual broadcasters for the first time – with the proviso that they came back to show the entire 1977 season, not just a pick-and-mix of whatever they fancied. It was the start of Formula 1’s drive to becoming a \$1 billion-a-year sporting and entertainment giant – and made Ecclestone a billionaire.

‘In the old days, the broadcasters would just show Monaco and something else and that was it,’ Ecclestone said. ‘But Niki was suddenly a massive star and everyone wanted to know how the 1976 season would end. It was a breakthrough for

Formula 1, otherwise we would still be stuck in Europe with very little coverage. I suppose it was all down to Niki and that crash.'

Lauda wasn't remotely interested in stardom and hated being noticed in restaurants or in the street. He had no time for gushing tributes or emotional moments. There was, perhaps, no better demonstration of his lack of sentimentality than his attitude towards his many trophies. Some found their way straight to the bin, but the man who ran his local garage showed some interest, so they struck a deal: he could have a trophy in return for free carwashes.

'That's what I did,' Lauda told the Reuters news agency. There was, however, a downside to this deal. 'The guy died, unfortunately, and his son was running the petrol station, so a friend of mine took them away, polished them and then my kids put them on eBay. Now I have to pay for the carwash.'

That lack of sentimentality reached every part of his working day, even for those closest to him. Paddy Lowe, Lauda's chief technical officer for three years at Mercedes, remembered: 'One Christmas, I had a Christmas card from Lewis [Hamilton] for him, a personally written card expressing his thanks to Niki for all he had done and wishing him all the best. Niki read it and threw it in the bin. I thought he could at least have taken it home. It was just like everything in his life – it was bullshit, and he didn't have time for bullshit.'

Even the scars that covered his head became an emblem to be exploited. Lauda had no vanity, no desire to look like James Hunt, the tall, blond Englishman he had competed against for the 1976 world championship. He accepted his scars and,

apart from some work to replace his eyelids, he never bothered with plastic surgery, simply putting on a red baseball cap to cover the burn marks on his bald head, which he then turned into a \$1 million-a-year advertising hoarding. Every setback could become a deal. He was matter-of-fact about his scars where others, such as Ian Wooldridge, were filled with horror. The celebrated *Daily Mail* sportswriter, who had witnessed the Nürburgring accident, wondered whether Lauda's return at Monza was an act of extraordinary courage or of stupendous folly. 'Is one man, aged 27, so unwilling to concede an earthly title that he is prepared to wager life against death when most men would be hiding their desperate injuries in a darkened room?' he wrote. Lauda was simply phlegmatic. 'I have reason to look ugly,' he told one interviewer. 'Most people don't. The cap is my protection from stupid people looking at me stupidly.'

The lack of an ear was also a source of both amusement and simple reality: 'People ask me, "Why did you never have an operation?" to which I would say, "Where the fuck do I find an ear?" It's a very simple answer,' he told Reuters.

His favourite story was of trying to recruit someone with acute observational skills. According to his narrative, he has each candidate come into the room to face the first question. 'What's the first thing you notice about me?' Most of the candidates fail, immediately pointing out his burnt ears, but one says: 'You are wearing contact lenses.' Lauda is surprised and pleased, but wants to know how the prospective employee figured it out. The answer came: 'If you had ears, you would be wearing glasses.'

Actually, there was one attempt to find Lauda's missing ear. After a fashion. Years after the 1976 crash, Bernie Ecclestone decided his old friend Lauda should return to the scene. They took along Karl-Heinz Zimmermann, Lauda's fellow Austrian who ran Ecclestone's motorhome at Grands Prix. Like Ecclestone, Zimmermann was an inveterate prankster and he guided the three of them around the old circuit – known as the Nordschleife and closed to Formula 1 after the 1976 accident – until they arrived at the Bergwerk turn where Lauda crashed and his Ferrari burst into flames.

The three stopped and wandered around the grass verge as if searching for something until a group of German passers-by spotted them and recognised Lauda. 'Hey, Niki Lauda,' one said. 'What are you doing?' Zimmermann was already prepared and shouted over: 'Looking for his ear, of course.' The Germans thought that Lauda and his friends were taking the mickey, but Zimmermann nudged Lauda and pointed at the ground in front of them. 'Look there,' he hissed. A quick scour of the verge uncovered a fresh, pink ear. Lauda emerged triumphant, waving it in the air at the Germans like a Formula 1 winner's trophy. It was, in fact, a pig's ear, which had been secreted in Zimmermann's pocket. The laughter was long and hearty, though the memories for Lauda must have been raw.

That fiery crash in 1976 deep in the forest of the Nordschleife could never leave him. It could have claimed his life in seconds there and then; instead, it took forty-three years to snuff out the irrepressible and undaunted Niki Lauda. This is the account of a life lived at speed, a life that went to hell, but came back to glory and fulfilment.

EARLY DAYS

COMING FROM A ‘good’ family has its advantages, although I question this at times when I think back to how angry I used to feel at being thrashed so often. In Austria, the Laudas are a ‘good’ family. At any rate they were. These days, Laudas of the captain-of-industry variety are something of a dying breed.

The most striking personality in the family was my grandfather, ‘Old Lauda’. Even now, after his death, the ‘old’ sets him apart from all the other Laudas (who, I imagine, also have hopes of living to a ripe old age). What I particularly liked about him was his physical presence, his sumptuous Vienna town house complete with liveried manservant, his sprawling estate in Lower Austria, his fabulous place in St Moritz.

Old Lauda saved his most original and graphic expletives to describe Socialism and all it stood for. One evening – I must have been about twelve at the time – I caught a glimpse of him on television. There he was in the front row at some ceremony or other, and there was Austria’s (then) Number One Socialist in the process of draping a ribbon and medal round his neck. I sat down at once and wrote grandfather a letter. I couldn’t understand (I wrote) how a person could rant and rave a lifetime long and then calmly accept an *Orden* from his worst adversaries. No reaction.

Months later, during one of his annual visits to our house, we came face to face. I was very pleased to see him because he

always let me park his Jaguar in our driveway. By this time most of our visitors let me take care of their cars – it saved them the trouble and they knew I was capable.

Anyway, after half an hour of small talk, Grandfather Lauda pulled my letter out of his top pocket. I was in for a dressing-down. What did I think I was playing at? How could I have the effrontery, etc., etc.? Pointing an accusing finger at my parents, he read the whole text out loud, every single phrase offering fresh evidence of my insufferable insolence. My mother was furious with me; my father took it more calmly.

As for myself, that was when I opted out of the we-Laudas-are-something-special way of thinking, such as I understood it then. As soon as I was more or less old enough to stand on my own two feet, I came back at Old Lauda with a vengeance: I pointedly kept my distance from his Christmas Day lunches at Vienna's most aristocratic hotel, the Imperial, when the entire clan was duty-bound to attend. At the time, Young Lauda considered no gesture more defiant.

Family background and education clearly explain much about my temperament today. I was brought up in a distinctly cold environment, in a milieu where certain truths are self-evident. Take horse-riding, for example. Although everything about it disgusted me, I had to learn to ride. Even the clip-clop of the hooves as the horse came out of the box would get on my nerves, and the stench literally got up my nose to the point where, in the early days, it made me physically sick.

However, not one single member of the family was flexible enough to suggest that a ten-year-old might be excused riding lessons and encouraged to take them up again later. There was

no concession, no way out. Looking back, of course, my parents were right. Despite everything, I shook off my phobia and learned to ride impeccably. Today, when the mood takes me, I ride my brother-in-law's horse on Ibiza, and I have a way with the children's ponies.

This proper but severe upbringing probably accounts for my addiction to excellence, my need to do things better than other people. It certainly helped in one respect: it gave me a lot of self-confidence.

Have you never noticed how, in an expensive restaurant, with bow-tied waiters slaloming from table to table, some people seem to change personality completely? They look different, they act differently, they make all kinds of outlandish gestures, crook their little fingers, etc. Not me. No matter where I am I have learned to be myself and act naturally, and feel totally confident in handling all manner of social situations.

My schooldays were highly enjoyable because I was careful not to let education get in the way. From my very first day at school I felt no sense of involvement, no commitment whatsoever. I simply couldn't see the point, particularly once I reached twelve or so and started taking a real interest in cars. I failed my first and third years in senior school, and had to repeat a year on both occasions. By then I already had wheels – a vintage-year (1949) drophead Beetle. It cost me £65 in saved-up pocket money, but it was a car I could drive around the courtyard and do a paint-job on, with an engine I could strip down and reassemble.

I had the VW towed out to my grandparents' estate, which had its own private roads where I could drive to my heart's

content. I also built a take-off ramp to see how far the Beetle would travel through the air: the record was twenty-four yards, with the springs popping out right, left and centre.

When I failed my third-year examinations for the second time, my parents enrolled me at a special school to do a university entrance course. Once there, I found I had a free hand, so I studied even less than before. I didn't sit one single examination; all I did was mess about. It finally dawned on my parents that the situation was getting out of hand, so they sent me off to do an apprenticeship as an auto-mechanic. I was coming up to seventeen. By Lauda family standards all this was very *infra dig*.

I ended up in a Volvo/BMW garage and thought to myself, hey, this is not too bad. Sadly, my new career soon took a sharp turn for the worse.

Early one morning, an agitated businessman brings in his Volvo. It is only about seven o'clock, but he has to have a quick oil-change because there's an important meeting at eight and he needs the car.

As far as the foreman is concerned, an oil-change is all that Lauda is fit for in life. I drive the Volvo downstairs and get it up on the ramp. I clamber down into the pit and try to loosen the nut on the sump. Unfortunately, I turn it too hard the wrong way and strip the threads. Back I go to report that I'm having a problem draining the sump – can the foreman come down and have a quick look? It doesn't take him a second to realise what has happened. There is one godawful row, because the whole engine has to be lifted out to get at the sump and remove it up through the hood. In goes a new sump, back goes

the engine – two days' work, the customer going bananas (he's the type who tends to get really emotional).

The other mechanics threw everything they could lay their hands on at me – screwdrivers and monkey wrenches went whizzing past my head. From that day on, I was the resident idiot. I wasn't allowed to lay a finger on any of the cars; the only job I was fit for was running errands.

During the summer vacation I took my driving test at my parents' place in the country. It was a fair distance from there to the driving school, so I used to drive myself to lessons in one of the various cars we had about the place, being careful to park round the corner out of sight of the driving instructor.

After a year of running errands I confessed to my father that I felt ready to return to college. Father took the point but, as a penance for all my transgressions to date, decreed that I would have to attend courses in the evening and continue working during the day.

I took studying a bit more seriously this time and managed to major in a couple of subjects. My grandfather promised me a small car if I passed English, but when I challenged him about this – in his twenty-bedroomed garret on the *Schubertring* – he told me not to be so impertinent. Couldn't I see for myself what a frugal life he led? And poor *Tante* Helga (his second wife), having to wear the same clothes year-in, year-out?

I asked my father about this and he said I shouldn't become too disappointed. Time and again, it appeared, Grandfather Lauda had promised him a horse, but had never delivered.

It was the height of humiliation for a nineteen-year-old in my social circle not to have a car. Everybody had wheels. It

was particularly embarrassing where girlfriends were concerned, because I could hardly expect them to travel by public transport.

There finally came a point when the whole situation got on top of me: the special school with all its upwardly mobiles, not to mention the fact that I had already wasted a precious year of my motor-racing career (which I had settled on a long time previously). I racked my brains for some way of speeding things along a bit so that I would never again have to worry about tiresome academic qualifications. I was absolutely convinced that I would never get myself into any profession that needed that sort of thing; it was all just a sop to my parents' ambition.

As it turned out, there *was* something I could do to hurry things along. A girlfriend at school had just graduated, and one of my schoolfriends thought he might be able to retouch her diploma so that my name would appear on it. The girl would then say she had lost hers and would apply for a duplicate.

Imagine my astonishment when I clapped eyes on the retouched diploma. My talented graphic-designer friend had dabbled with erasers and ink-remover so amateurishly that you could tell the thing was a fake from a hundred yards away.

I quickly reviewed the legal ramifications of what I had in mind, coming to the conclusion that a forgery executed for purely 'domestic purposes' couldn't be all that serious. Come what may, I decided to take the scrap of paper home with me. Standing at a safe distance from my audience I held the paper up, waved it about, tucked it back in my pocket and, leaving the room as quickly as possible, immediately destroyed it.

It worked like a dream. The news coursed through the Lauda dynasty like wildfire: OUR NIKI HAS GRADUATED! At long last I could concentrate on the things that really mattered in life.

I used graduation gifts from relatives to buy a VW Beetle that was going for £650. Then, one evening, Peter Draxler, my old schoolfriend, who still didn't have a driving licence, suggested that we go for a drive. Not in my boring old Beetle, of course, but in a chic Mini Cooper S which his dad has in the garage and is trying to sell for £1,750.

Draxler Jr duly 'borrows' the car. I drive it.

We are shifting along quite nicely – no doubt, as Draxler now maintains, the first signs of a future world champion were in evidence – until we blast into the *Höhenstrasse* in Vienna at about four in the morning. I hit a patch of frost on one of the bridges, skid, and the car slams sideways against a high kerb. The near-side wheels buckle, and the bodywork is bent and twisted out of all recognition.

Draxler's father was an imposing figure. Draxler Jr and I were in deep trouble – until Peter suddenly had a bright idea: 'If you buy the car, he won't have to know anything about what happened.'

I dash down from the *Höhenstrasse* to my grandmother's apartment, ring the bell, get her out of bed and tell her I have just written off a set of wheels – to the tune of £1,750 – and that it's prison for Niki if I don't pay up. Grandmother gets dressed, drives me to the bank first thing in the morning, and gives me that amount in cash. I hurry round to Draxler Sr.

'... Incidentally, sir, I wouldn't mind buying your car.'

So, overnight, I become the proud owner of two cars – a clapped-out VW and a smashed-up Mini. I sell the VW and apply the proceeds to a repair job on the Mini.

Those were the days of the great Fritz Baumgartner, the ‘Mini-King’ and, for me, one of the great personalities of Austrian motor-sport. He had just advertised in *Autorevue* that he was selling his racing version Mini Cooper S. There I was, no academic qualifications, no job prospects, no money, no nothing. But I drove out to Baden where Baumgartner’s car was garaged and looked it over. A dark-blue racing version. Minus engine.

Baumgartner saw me nosing around the car and came over to say hello. To me, he was some sort of god. We seemed to hit it off, and one day he visited me at my parents’ house. That was an eye-opener for him; it seemed to convince him that I was someone he could do business with.

We pieced the racing engine together in my parents’ garage and struck a bargain: he would trade me the Racing S for my street Mini (now repaired) plus £650; naturally, there was no need for me to worry about paying him the cash right away.

Within the shortest time imaginable, I had gone from zero to racing car. My non-existent diploma had underwritten the VW; the VW had metamorphosed into a Mini; and the Mini had been swapped for a racing version (albeit not fully paid off).

My family got wind of the fact that I was out in the garage tinkering around with a racing car. I told them that all I was interested in was the mechanical challenge which would help develop my engineering skills. I did have to promise, however, that I wouldn’t race.

My first race came a couple of days later, on 15 April 1968. I travelled with my new sponsor (Baumgartner) to a place called Mühlacken in Upper Austria. A hill climb. In the first run I stuck to the 9,000-rev limit Baumgartner had recommended, eased up and finished third. I had a word with Baumgartner and he advised me to red-line (exceed the recommended rpm) in short bursts. I did this on the second run and won. When the two times were aggregated, however, I was only placed second overall.

Meanwhile Fritz Baumgartner's conscience had been playing him up, or maybe he was getting jumpy about the money I still owed him. Either way, he went behind my back and confessed all to my father: I had taken part in my first race, I was actually very talented, but Baumgartner would move heaven and earth to stop me entering the next one on the calendar. This was the Dobratsch Hill Climb, he explained, a very difficult one; a European Championship event with dangerous corners and a sheer drop to the valley floor. At all costs I had to be talked out of it.

With this ploy, Fritz Baumgartner contrived to act the concerned friend; he probably also contrived to collect the £650 he had coming to him, since I assume my father paid up.

My father made a tremendous song and dance, furious at my lies and deceit. He brought the full weight of paternal authority to bear to ensure that I would not enter the Dobratsch Hill Climb. I was to have no illusions on that score, he warned.

I found myself in a ridiculous situation. I didn't have a car that I could drive around town in, I had to suffer the indignity of my girlfriend travelling by public transport, I had a racing

car without plates sitting around in the garage, and now I had been forbidden to race again. I analysed the situation from every angle and decided *que sera, sera*: I would be at Dobratsch on 28 April.

A friend from school lent me his father's BMW V8, which had a trailer attachment. Another friend lent me £125 for gas. In the middle of the night I wheeled the Mini out of the garage and loaded it onto the trailer. Then, with Ursula Pischinger, my girlfriend, I made tracks for Dobratsch.

The Mini choked and spluttered abominably at first, so I asked yet another friend if his mechanic could tune it for me.

I got in, drove smoothly, and won my class.

By the time I got back home my father had already seen the results in the newspaper. That was it: he'd finally had enough of me. As soon as I could afford to, I moved – out of the parental home and in with Mariella Reininghaus in Salzburg.

It took years for us to reconcile our differences. It was not until I was well on my way in Formula 1 that my father finally gave in and admitted there was nothing more he could do to stop me. However, in the period leading up to his death we grew very close. As for my mother and grandmother (who had stood by me in my hour of need), our relationship is still very close to this day, although we all too seldom see one another. Grandfather Lauda, the old patriarch himself? More about him later.

I suppose the question might as well come up now: *why* was I so completely and utterly determined to be a racing driver?

Answer: I don't know. That's just the way it was. There was not one single thing in the world that interested me even a

fraction as much. Studying or having a 'normal' profession was totally alien to my way of thinking. Once in the sport, however, my approach has always been very level-headed and pragmatic: I have always thought my career through one step at a time, starting with the need for a driving licence and dealing with each subsequent problem as and when it came up.

I never craved stardom, I never identified with anyone (although there was a real candidate for hero-worship in those days in the person of Jim Clark).

Clark died in a shunt exactly one week before my first race. I can remember it to this day. I was watching a race in Aspern. Just as the race was finishing, it came over the PA system that Clark had been killed at Hockenheim. The news went through me like a knife and I was very depressed: what a shame, I thought, he'll be missed, the world will be a poorer place without him. I had no sense of drama about his death, no feeling of awesome tragedy. It never crossed the mind of a nineteen-year-old that the weeks, months and years ahead would be just as dangerous for me.

Jochen Rindt was another individual I didn't identify with, although, of course, he really impressed me. In November 1969, as part of a public relations exercise to promote the Jochen Rindt Show, he took the incredible Green Monster out on the apron at Aspern airport. I was in the crowd that day and saw Jochen in a superb full-length fur coat. A coat like that would have looked incredibly stupid on any other man, but on him it looked truly majestic. He came right across to where I was standing and shook hands with me. This came as

a total surprise and I was naturally delighted and proud. His death a year later hit me very hard.

My first year in racing – 1968 – was an important one for the sport. Changes were coming fast and furious. I told myself I'd better not hang about too long wasting valuable career time.

Eight weeks after my first outing in the Mini Cooper I was already behind the wheel of a Porsche 911 (financed by trading in the Mini, a quick pilgrimage to my two grandmothers and a further – inevitable – bank loan). I seemed to have an easier time raising cash than most youngsters of my age; one look at my parents' villa seemed to put a creditor's mind at ease.

I raced in hill climbs and round airfields and did fairly well; well enough at least to draw attention to myself. I was offered a Formula Vee spot in 1969 in Kurt Bergmann's Kaimann team; the same team in which Keke Rosberg was to make a name for himself two years later.

My Formula 3 year, 1970, saw me up to my ears in debt and without a care in the world. Fact is, you can't afford worries when you're in Formula 3 because you have to keep your wits about you to cope with the utter madness of it. Technically speaking, there is precious little difference between one Formula 3 car and another. There are some twenty-five drivers in the field, all as fast as each other. And nobody gives an inch. We used to come over the top in formation at 125mph plus, jostling and banging into each other like dodgem cars in the *Prater* fairground. You had to be crazy to drive in Formula 3 at all. Back in 1970, I fitted the bill.

My first start in Formula 3 was typical of my whole season. I travelled down to Nogaro in the South of France with another

Austrian driver, Gerold Pankl – thirty-six hours on the road with a flat-bed trailer toting two racing cars.

We are the only two Austrians in a field of thirty mad Frenchmen. First training lap: I slot into Pankl's slip-stream, close up and scissor out past him. Just that instant, his engine dies on him. My left front wheel catches his rear right, I take off, hurtle through the air, come down just ahead of the guard-rail, lose all four wheels, and plough some hundred yards along the rail. There isn't too much of the car left after that. So much for my first five minutes of exposure to Formula 3.

Even so, I had absolutely no problem clearing my mind of images like that and stopping myself worrying about them. Just as well, since I spun out time and again.

We drove back at breakneck speed from Nogaro to Vienna, and I went over into Germany to buy myself a new chassis. I got the car back together (more debts) and made my way to the Nürburgring: I'm lying fifth, with no one in my sights and no one coming up behind me, and I suddenly spin out. To this day, I've never been able to figure out why.

Then came another thirty-six-hour haul to France. During the race something gets snarled up when I'm changing gears, I shift down instead of up, and bang go gearbox and engine.

Brands Hatch: Alois Rottensteiner, the photographer, asks me before the race which corner I think he should position himself at. 'Just ahead of the pits, somebody's bound to lose it there.' No sooner said than done: Lauda tries to outbrake someone, cuts in too sharply ahead of him, the driver behind clips his rear wheel and, whoops, there he goes, smack in front of Rottensteiner. A total write-off.

Now and again, though, I did finish a race, placing anywhere from second to sixth; not bad in the tight conditions of Formula 3 with people like James Hunt up against you.

The shunts didn't worry me at first. It wasn't until 5 September 1970 that I started to see things differently. That happened to be the day Jochen Rindt was killed at Monza, but what triggered my change of heart had nothing to do with him. Thinking about his death made me extremely sad, but it didn't influence me one way or another.

What did influence me was a Formula 3 outing at Dolder.

Lap three: Hannelore Werner becomes involved in a shunt somewhere out on the circuit. We come over a crest in formation doing 130mph. Right in front of us is an ambulance doing 30. The first three cars squeeze out to the right and through. James Hunt among them. And Gerry Birrell. Then a fourth tries, doesn't quite make it, oversteers and goes into a spin. I go out left, but the car that's spinning swings across in front of me. We collide, I spin, the car behind catches me on the volley. All of this is happening right out in the middle of the track. I sit in my wreck and here comes the next wave in tight formation over the crest of the hill. Yellow flags are out by this time and all kinds of signals are being flashed, but none of the pack coming through even considers easing off. All I can do is sit tight and wait for them to ram me: left, right or dead centre. One shoots straight over the nose of my car. That's it. I jump clear and make a run for it.

This incident was the high point of my third racing season (or should I say, non-season?). The day I started to develop one of my special talents: thinking things through, analysing, setting one goal at a time.

What it boiled down to was this: yes, I wanted to be in racing, always had done. But I didn't want to be one nutcase in a field of two dozen other nutcases. There was one logical conclusion – get out of Formula 3 and move up a class to Formula 2 as fast as possible.

There would be a lot of financial hardship involved. It would mean doubling the ante without having won a single game.